

Justification trajectories for pension inequality in Chile (2016-2023): The role of beliefs in meritocracy and social stratification

Juan Carlos Castillo¹, René Canales², Andreas Laffert³, Tomás Urzúa⁴

¹Departament of Sociology, University of Chile

²Institute of Sociology, Pontifical Catholic University of Chile

³Institute of Sociology, Pontifical Catholic University of Chile

⁴Departament of Sociology, University of Chile

Abstract

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1 Introduction

The pension system is at the core of the welfare state, playing a key role in shaping income distribution among the elderly population ([Brezna, 2023](#); [Esping-Andersen, 1990](#)). This system is based on a shared understanding that older adults require financial support after retirement, whereby pensions are designed to provide such support. In such an understanding, justice principles held in a society are crucial, as they influence how individuals perceive the fairness of pension systems and the distribution of benefits in a society ([Liebig & Sauer, 2016](#)). For instance, in systems that emphasize social solidarity, there may be a greater support towards redistributive mechanisms to ensure a more equitable distribution of pension benefits across different social groups. Conversely, in societies where meritocratic beliefs are prevalent, individuals may justify inequalities in pension benefits based on factors such as work history, contributions to the system, and individual effort ([Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2024](#); [Mijs, 2019](#)).

The Chilean pension system is a classical case study when it comes to privatization based on individual contributions, whereby those with higher lifetime earnings tend to receive higher pension benefits, while those with lower earnings often face inadequate pensions. Such system has created large disparities and increased poverty rates among the elderly, making them struggle to make ends meet ([Borzutzky & Hyde, 2016](#); [Bril-Mascarenhas & Maillet, 2019](#); [Cabib, 2025](#); [C. Evans & Pienknagura, 2024](#); [Subsecretaría de Previsión Social, 2023](#)). In this scenario, a deep discontent and social movements demanding reforms of the pension system have emerged in recent years. Nevertheless, and despite this discontent, some studies have shown that an important and growing share of the population is willing to justify inequalities in pensions based on individual contributions ([Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2025](#)). In such a context, under-

standing how meritocratic beliefs and social class influence the justification of inequalities in pensions acquires relevance for informing policy debates and promoting social justice (Busemeyer & Iversen, 2020; Svallfors, 2006).

The concept of market justice refers to the belief that the distribution of goods and services (as pensions) should be determined by market mechanisms, such as supply and demand, rather than by social or political considerations (Lane, 1986; Lindh, 2015). More specifically, research on market justice focuses on individual payment capacity and contribution as the main criteria for distributing resources, emphasizing personal responsibility and effort over collective welfare (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2024; ?). Within this framework, the present paper aims to analyze how meritocratic beliefs and social class are associated with the preferences of market justice in pensions in Chile, and how these associations have evolved between 2016 and 2023. On the one hand, social class has been shown to influence individuals' perceptions of justice and fairness in various social contexts, including pensions, as it shapes their experiences and access to resources (Svallfors, 2006). In this regard, individuals from higher social classes may be more likely to justify inequalities in pensions, as they may benefit more from the existing system. On the other hand, meritocracy is a widely held belief that individuals should be rewarded based on their abilities and efforts (McNamee & Miller, 2004; Young, 1975). In the context of pensions, this belief may lead individuals to justify inequalities in pension benefits based on their contributions to the system.

To address these issues, we utilize data from the Chilean Longitudinal Social Survey (ELSOC) conducted between 2016 and 2023. This survey provides a comprehensive overview of public attitudes towards social justice issues in Chile, including perceptions of pensions and income distribution. By analyzing this data, we aim to shed light on the complex interplay between meritocratic beliefs, social class, and the justification of inequalities in pensions in Chile over time.

The paper is structured as follows. First, we review the relevant literature on meritocratic beliefs, social class, and the justification of inequalities in pensions. Next, we describe the data and methodology used in our analysis. We then present our findings on the associations between meritocratic beliefs, social class, and the justification of inequalities in pensions in Chile from 2016 to 2023. Finally, we discuss the implications of our findings for policy and future research.

2 Theoretical and empirical background

2.1 Market justice preferences

In recent years, welfare states have undergone several institutional transformations, with market expansion strongly penetrating the field of social services and rights, while private alternatives emerge in parallel to public provision (Busemeyer & Iversen, 2020). Such processes have led to changes in the architecture of the institutions responsible for social welfare, where private companies operate as service administrators that limit access based on the user's ability to pay, while public providers have reorganized to compete as quasi-markets (Lindh, 2017). Despite the commodification of services, this does not only imply changes at the formal level, but also shapes the beliefs of individuals. In this way, market-oriented

policies can modify people's normative criteria, promoting or weakening support for different goods or services. This phenomenon is known as *policy feedback effect*. (Béland & Schlager, 2019; Jaime-Castillo, 2013).

In distributive justice field, market preferences have gained relevance in attitudinal studies on redistribution. In this context, market justice emerges as one of the central concepts in this literature, understood as a normative principle that legitimizes access to goods and services based on individual or family ability to pay, the basis of which is radically opposed to social justice (Lane, 1986). This market-oriented redistribution is closely related to the justification of inequalities, as it considers the market to be a space of equal opportunity, where economic success is understood as an individual outcome (J. Kluegel et al., 1999). In this way, market justice legitimizes socioeconomic inequalities from an economic-moral perspective, ignoring the structural conditions that generate disparities.

Research strategies on market preferences have focused on operationalizing this concept in order to empirically study how individuals' beliefs are shaped by macro-structural conditions, such as the application of privatization policies to goods such as education, health, or pensions (Busemeyer, 2013; Kerner, 2020; Lindh, 2015). The inaugural study in this line of research was by J. R. Kluegel & Smith (1981), analyzing the normative bases of beliefs about social stratification. Subsequently, market preferences have been studied in detail in surveys, where International Social Survey Program (ISSP) has led the comparative study between countries focused on social inequality, asking how fair it is considered that those with higher incomes have access to better education, health, and/or pensions from 1999 to the present day (Immergut & Schneider, 2020; Lindh, 2015). In this frame, ISSP has been one of the most important resources for building a market justice agenda. There are also studies that have measured market preferences using an index constructed from three items referring to market justice in the three main social services, operationalizing the concept of preferences for market justice (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2025). In short, all the strategies employed seek to understand the extent to which market-generated inequalities are legitimized.

Recent literature on market preferences has found striking associations with both individual and contextual factors. Various studies suggest that people with higher socioeconomic status tend to adopt greater market preferences than those who are in a more disadvantaged social position (Koos & Sachweh, 2019; Lindh, 2015). Similarly, political ideology has been linked to preferences for market justice, with right-wing individuals mostly supporting market-oriented distribution (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2024; Lee & Stacey, 2024). These trends reflect a moral economy based on the justification of status by those who enjoy the benefits of the market. With regard to contextual factors, evidence suggests that in countries with greater private investment in services, individuals tend to decrease their preferences for redistribution, internalizing the market order as a criterion of justice, while in countries where public provision of services prevails, individuals show resistance to market-induced inequalities (Busemeyer, 2013; Immergut & Schneider, 2020; Lindh, 2015).

In the market justice frame, pensions have been one of the most studied elements due to their centrality in discussions of economic distribution among the elderly population (Arenas, 2019). Some pension systems are based on principles of solidarity, demonstrating solid security systems. On the other hand, there are

pension systems based on privatization policies, managing resources according to market logic such as investments, which runs counter to principles of solidarity (Arrizabalo Montoro et al., 2019). Pension system policies have cultural implications for societies. For example, market-oriented plans are associated with feelings of insecurity due to the individualization of risk. (?). From a broader perspective, depending on the policies applied in pension systems, these have a positive or negative effect on preferences for market justice (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2025).

2.2 Meritocracy

Meritocracy is a normative principle that justifies the distribution of goods and services based on individual effort and talent, emphasizing that rewards should correspond to personal achievements rather than social status or inherited privileges (?; ?). This concept has gained prominence in contemporary societies, where meritocratic ideals are often invoked to legitimize socioeconomic inequalities, suggesting that individuals' success or failure is primarily determined by their own merits (Littler, 2018).

Research on meritocratic beliefs has explored how individuals perceive the fairness of social systems that prioritize merit-based distribution. Studies have shown that people who strongly endorse meritocratic ideals tend to justify existing inequalities, attributing success to personal effort and downplaying the role of structural factors such as social class (Reynolds & Xian, 2014). This perspective can lead to reduced support for redistributive policies, as individuals may view such interventions as undermining the principles of meritocracy (Piketty, 2014).

Empirical investigations have also examined the relationship between meritocratic beliefs and various demographic and ideological factors. For instance, individuals with higher socioeconomic status are more likely to endorse meritocratic ideals, as they often benefit from systems that reward their efforts and talents (Harris & Sterba, 2025). Additionally, political ideology plays a significant role, with right-leaning individuals typically exhibiting stronger support for meritocracy compared to their left-leaning counterparts. Contextual factors also influence meritocratic beliefs. Although in societies with high levels of social mobility and equal opportunities, individuals may be more inclined to endorse meritocratic ideals, some evidence suggest that inequality is linked to larger meritocratic perception, aka the paradox of meritocracy (Mijs, 2021). Overall, the concept of meritocracy remains a central theme in discussions about social justice and inequality, highlighting the complex interplay between individual effort, structural conditions, and societal values.

The measurement of meritocratic beliefs has been approached through various survey instruments that assess individuals' attitudes towards effort, talent, and the fairness of merit-based systems. Commonly used items include questions about the importance of hard work for success, the role of innate ability, and perceptions of fairness in competitive environments (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2023). In the extant literature the measurement of meritocratic beliefs has often been inconsistent, with different studies employing varying scales and items, making cross-study comparisons challenging. To address this issue, some researchers have advocated for the development of standardized measures that capture the multifaceted nature of meritocratic beliefs. A first distinction to make here is the one between perceptions and preferences for meritocracy, usually the first being descriptive and the second more normative in nature (Juan

Carlos Castillo et al., 2023). Research on meritocratic perceptions have reveal that people's beliefs about the extent to which meritocracy exists in society can differ significantly from their normative support for meritocratic principles (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2023). Besides, whereas meritocratic preferences are usually more consensual, meritocratic perceptions tend to vary more across individuals and contexts.

2.3 Social class

Despite criticism of class analysis as a category for studying social order (Pakulski & Waters, 1997), various contemporary studies have shown that class inequalities remain relevant as a subject of research for explaining attitudes towards social justice (Dodson, 2017; ?; ?). Different approaches, from neo-Marxist (Wright, 2000) to neo-Weberian (Breen, 2005), agree that people's different socioeconomic positions act as determinants of how material interests and shared life experiences structure individuals' subjective perceptions of social reality and the justification of certain inequalities present in the system (?).

Material interests derived from class position constitute a fundamental bridge between the objective structure of inequality, perceptions of justice, political positioning, and distribution of resources (G. Evans et al., 2022; Langsæther & Evans, 2020; ?). Along these lines, various studies recognise that the position individuals occupy in the class structure—whether subordinate or privileged—produces significant variations in how they perceive and justify different social inequalities within market frameworks (Langsæther & Evans, 2020; Svallfors, 2006). In the context of pension systems based on individual contributions, such as the Chilean system, these distinctions are particularly relevant, as they allow us to differentiate preferences and perceptions regarding a system from which some people benefit while others remain in vulnerable positions according to their class position.

Class theory in welfare states suggests that positions in the labour market define similarities in economic resources, opportunities and constraints, structuring both economic interests and group identities (Erikson & Goldthorpe, 1992a; Korpi & Palme, 2003). From this perspective, the strong dependence on market linkages in distributive processes mainly empowers class categories that are well equipped with scarce productive resources, while people in positions characterised by fewer marketable resources benefit more from political distribution based on social citizenship (Korpi, 2006, 2018). In the specific case of social services, different methods of provision have different class distribution profiles: private financing imposes higher costs on the individual and links access to the recipient's income profile, potentially restricting access for low-income or high-risk groups (Gingrich, 2011). Therefore, from a rational actor perspective, people in class positions with greater marketable assets are expected to be more favourable towards market distribution than those in positions characterised by fewer assets and greater risks (?).

However, policy feedback theories emphasise that social policy institutions structure both economic incentives and normative frames of reference (Pierson, 1993; Rothstein, 1998; Svallfors, 2007). This perspective suggests that class conflict is shaped by institutions, and that normative beliefs about the market may be influenced by the social and institutional context in which citizens are embedded (Svallfors, 2006). Empirical research on the relationship between social position and perceptions of justice has shown a consistent pattern: perceptions of fairness tend to be structured according to people's social position (Edlund & Lindh, 2015; Pérez Ahumada, 2024). In this sense, while the lower classes tend to be less accepting

of inequality and more in favour of redistribution, the upper classes tend to be more accepting of these inequalities on the basis of meritocratic criteria (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2025; ?, ?). This pattern can be explained by the fact that people in privileged positions experience less impairment of their material interests and tend to perceive their own situation as the result of their effort and qualifications (?), while justifying access to certain services as fair competition in the market based on their ability to pay (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2025).

In the specific case of Chile, the individually funded pension system has generated enormous disparities and vulnerability among the elderly population, creating a scenario in which the justification for these inequalities takes on special importance (Borzutzky & Hyde, 2016; Bril-Mascarenhas & Maillet, 2019; Cabib, 2025; C. Evans & Pienknagura, 2024; Subsecretaría de Previsión Social, 2023). Despite documented social discontent, recent studies have identified that a significant proportion of the population is willing to justify pension inequalities based on meritocratic beliefs and notions of market justice (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2025). This apparent contradiction suggests that beliefs about how pensions should be distributed do not necessarily align with the objective material interests of the classes, raising questions about how social class and meritocratic beliefs interact in the justification of inequalities.

Understanding how meritocratic beliefs and social position are related to the justification of pension inequalities is fundamental to understanding both the persistence of social discontent and the acceptance of highly unequal systems (Busemeyer & Iversen, 2020; Svallfors, 2006). Preferences for market justice in pensions represent a specific political expression of how individuals, based on their class position, evaluate the legitimacy of a system that distributes resources in a differentiated manner (Iturra-Sanhueza, 2025). However, policy feedback theories suggest that welfare state institutions not only structure material incentives, but also the normative frameworks that citizens use to evaluate policy performance (Kerner, 2020; Pierson, 1993). In individually funded pension systems, investment returns can serve as particularly clear signals of system performance, influencing how participants retrospectively judge its effectiveness (Kerner, 2020). This suggests that attitudes towards market fairness in pensions are not formed solely on the basis of static class interests, but also in response to the perceived performance of the system. Analysing these associations over time allows us to identify how these justifications evolve and what factors explain why some groups maintain or modify their assessments of what constitutes a fair pension system.

2.4 The Chilean context

Pension systems occupy a central place in the welfare state, as they shape the distribution of income and risks in old age (Arenas, 2019; Breznau, 2023; Esping-Andersen, 1990). While they share the fundamental premise that older adults require financial support after retirement and that pension income can be understood as deferred wages reflecting past contributions, the principles of justice underpinning their design vary considerably across societies (Verbič & Spruk, 2019). In contexts where ideals of social solidarity are prominent, redistributive mechanisms permit a more equal sharing of resources and risks across social groups. By contrast, where meritocratic beliefs are stronger, inequalities in pensions are more readily justified in terms of employment histories, individual contributions, and personal effort (Busemeyer &

Iversen, 2020; Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2024; ?; ?). Analysing these justice principles—and their influence on support for different pension arrangements—is therefore crucial for understanding the legitimacy of welfare institutions (Mau, 2015).

Despite sustained economic growth during the 1990s, Chile remains one of the most unequal countries in Latin America and the OECD (Flores et al., 2020). The poorest 50% of the population earn around 10% of total income and hold negative net wealth, while the wealthiest 1% receive almost 27% of income and control roughly half of national wealth (Chancel et al., 2022). These inequalities are not simply the outcome of market forces. They are rooted in neoliberal reforms that privatised and commodified key spheres of social reproduction (Ferre, 2023; PNUD, 2017). Introduced under the military dictatorship (1973–1989) and subsequently expanded by democratic governments, these reforms entrenched market logics in essential public services through concessions and regulatory frameworks that favoured private provision, producing a model of commodified public services that underpins Chile’s neoliberal order (Madariaga, 2020). Health and education have been extensively studied in this regard (Llambías-Wolff, 2019; Rosenzvaig-Hernandez, 2024), revealing structurally segmented systems in which access and quality depend heavily on the ability to pay (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2025). In this setting, class trajectories unfold under conditions of high inequality and market-based provision in core welfare domains, including pensions.

Since 1981, old-age income security in Chile has been organised primarily through a fully privatised, mandatory defined-contribution scheme. A far-reaching reform replaced the previous earnings-related, pay-as-you-go social insurance system with individual capitalisation accounts administered by private Pension Fund Administrators (AFP) (Huber & Stephens, 2000; Solimano, 2021). Under this design, dependent employees must contribute 10% of their wages, plus an administrative fee, to individual accounts, while employers face no mandatory contributions. AFPs invest these savings in domestic and international financial markets, and since the early 2000s, affiliates are assigned to, or choose among, several “multifunds” (A–E) with distinct risk–return profiles (Hyde & Borzutzky, 2015; ?). After more than four decades, benefit levels remain modest: for most retirees, AFP-financed pensions fall below the statutory minimum wage, and self-funded replacement rates hover around 30%, even among workers with long and dense contribution records (Gálvez et al., 2024; Madero-Cabib et al., 2019). To secure a minimum income in old age, the state has progressively introduced tax-financed solidarity components—most notably the *Nuevo Pilar Solidario* (2008) and the *Pensión Garantizada Universal* (PGU, 2022)—which top up low or non-existent contributory pensions among poorer and lower-middle older adults (Boccardo, 2020). In practice, this has produced a hybrid arrangement in which privately managed individual accounts are substantially subsidised by the state, and tax-funded transfers constitute a significant share of total pension income at the bottom of the distribution (Gálvez et al., 2024). For instance, in 2023, half of all old-age pensioners received less than about the 75% of the minimum wage, and this figure drops when state transfers from the PGU or the Solidarity Pension Contribution are excluded.

This institutional configuration both reflects and reinforces Chile’s broader pattern of persistent inequality combined with extensive welfare privatisation. Stratified access to social protection has eroded expectations of upward mobility and contributed to social unrest, with pensions becoming a focal point of public

discontent and protest (PNUD, 2017; Rozas Bugueño & Maillet, 2019). At the same time, the attitudinal landscape is not univocal. Recent evidence shows that, alongside widespread criticism of the private pension system and repeated demands for reform, an increasing share of the population considers pension inequalities based on individual contribution histories to be fair or legitimate (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2025). These developments are embedded in broader transformations of Chile’s class structure and moral orientations. Meritocratic beliefs have intensified, accompanying the diffusion of market-centred moral frameworks in which individuals and families are expected to act as self-responsible agents, investing in their own “market value” and bearing the risks of their life-course trajectories (Canales Cerón et al., 2021; Mau, 2015). In a context marked by high and durable inequalities, deep marketisation of welfare, and the growing entrenchment of meritocratic beliefs, it becomes crucial to examine how pension inequalities are justified, how these justifications vary across social classes and meritocratic orientations, and how they have evolved (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2025; Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2024).

2.5 This study

First, findings from previous research have found that higher class position is associated with skepticism toward redistributive policies (Koos & Sachweh, 2019). More specifically, the upper classes tend to prefer market-based distribution to a greater extent than those in less privileged positions (Lindh, 2015). When individuals have the ability to pay for quality services, their principles of justice align with this logic, making them more likely to view market mechanisms as legitimate and accept that the distribution of goods depends on purchasing power.

Secondly, the literature has pointed out that perceived meritocracy is positively associated with market preferences for goods and services, especially pensions, both at a specific point in time and longitudinally (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2025; Juan-Carlos Castillo et al., 2019). Those who believe that effort and talent determine success tend to support market-oriented distribution, as they consider that this reflects the results of individual effort (Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2024). In this way, meritocratic perceptions operate as an argument to legitimize market justice insofar as an individual’s ability to pay is proportional to the effort they have put in.

Additionally, this research examines the interaction between class and meritocracy in shaping market preferences. Specifically, we argue that the relationship between an individual’s socioeconomic position and market preference for pensions is moderated by meritocratic perceptions. When individuals have high meritocratic perceptions, the positive association between class and market preferences for pensions will be stronger in upper classes than in lower classes. This interaction is studied at an inter-individual level, and with an exploratory intent, we also look at how changes over time can reveal an intra-individual evolution in the way class and meritocracy shape market preferences for pensions.

Based on the arguments outlined above, we propose the following hypotheses:

H1 (Between-person) : Those belonging to the upper classes show, on average, greater support for the commodification of pensions than those belonging to the lower classes.

H2_a (Between-person) : People who perceive more meritocracy tend to show greater support for the

commodification of pensions than those who hold these perceptions less strongly.

$H2_b$ (Within-person) : When the same person strengthens their meritocratic perceptions over time, their support for the commodification of pensions increases.

$H3_a$ (Between-person) : The positive association between meritocracy (BE) and support for commodification is stronger in upper classes.

$H3_b$ (Within-person) : When upper-class individuals increase their meritocratic perceptions over time (WE), their support for commodification rises more than in lower classes.

3 Data, Variables and Methods

3.1 Data

For this study, we used the Chilean Longitudinal Social Survey (ELSOC). This is a panel study conducted annually between 2016 and 2023, designed to examine the attitudes, emotions, and behaviours of people aged 18 to 75 with regard to issues of social cohesion and conflict. In terms of methodology, the survey uses a probabilistic, stratified, clustered, multistage sampling design covering urban centres and small towns. The sampling frame is stratified proportionally into six categories of urban population size, followed by random selection of households within 1,067 blocks.

The survey has been conducted annually since 2016, with the exception of 2020, when it was suspended due to the COVID-19 pandemic. For the purposes of this study, the 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2022, and 2023 waves were used. The 2021 wave was excluded because the version of the questionnaire omitted variables of interest. Between waves 1 and 6, panel attrition reached 40%, so a balanced panel was used, resulting in a final two-level sample comprising $N = 5,755$ observations nested in $N = 1,027$ individuals. Further details on sampling, attrition, and weighting procedures are available at <https://coes.cl/encuesta-panel/>, and the dataset is publicly accessible at <https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataverse/elsoc>.

3.2 Variables

3.2.1 Market justice preferences for pensions

The dependent variable in this study is distributive justice in pensions. This construct is measured by a single item that captures how strongly individuals endorse conditioning access to better pensions on income. Specifically, the question is: “Is it fair that high-income individuals have better pensions than lower-income individuals?” The response options range from 1 (“Strongly disagree”) to 5 (“Strongly agree”). Therefore, higher values indicate a greater perception of fairness in pension distribution, i.e., greater support for inequality in pensions.

3.2.2 Social class

As for the independent variables, a class scheme was constructed based on that of Erikson, Goldthorpe and Portocarero (EGP) (Erikson & Goldthorpe, 1992b), collapsed into three categories: (1) Working class (V+VI+VII), which serves as the reference category, (2) Intermediate class (III+IV), (3) Service class (I+II). Additionally, a residual category is included that considers people outside the labour force according to their statements in the survey.

We employ the EGP scheme because it captures theoretically relevant dimensions of labor market position for understanding distributive justice attitudes. Unlike occupational prestige scales or purely income-based measures, EGP distinguishes positions based on employment relations and market situations—specifically, the degree of autonomy, job security, and contractual conditions (Barone et al., 2022; Barozet et al., 2021) that structure both contributions to the pension system and expected returns. This is crucial for our analysis since different class positions imply distinct relationships with pension schemes: service class workers typically benefit from stable employment and higher contribution rates, while working class positions face greater employment instability and lower coverage. The collapsed three-category version balances theoretical meaningfulness with statistical power, maintaining the core distinction between labor contract types (labor contracts for the working class, service relationships for the service class, and mixed positions for the intermediate class) while ensuring adequate sample sizes for longitudinal analysis.

The conversion from ISCO-08 occupational codes to EGP categories was performed using the *occupar* R package, which incorporates information on employment status (self-employed versus employee) and number of employees for self-employed workers. This approach follows the theoretical logic that class position depends not only on occupational title but also on employment relations, allowing us to differentiate, for example, between small-scale self-employed workers (petty bourgeoisie, class IVc) and employers with larger workforces (class I-II). A recognized limitation in contexts like Chile is EGP’s difficulty in adequately capturing labor informality, as it was designed for formalized labor markets. However, this limitation is shared by most available occupational classification schemes and does not invalidate its analytical utility for the formal sector, which constitutes the base of the contributory pension system under normative evaluation in our dependent variable.

3.2.3 Meritocracy

Following Young’s (1975) distinction, this construct is operationalised into two dimensions: effort and talent. Both dimensions are measured by the degree of agreement with statements indicating that effort and talent are rewarded in society. Specifically, meritocratic perceptions of effort are captured by the item “In Chile, people are rewarded for their efforts” (Merit: Effort), and meritocratic perceptions of talent by the item “In Chile, people are rewarded for their intelligence and abilities” (Merit: Talent). Both items are answered on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (“Strongly disagree”) to 5 (“Strongly agree”), with higher values indicating stronger perceptions that Chilean society operates according to meritocratic principles.

Table 1 shows the main variables of the study, their response categories and their frequencies.

Table 1: Variable descriptive statistics for the last wave (2023)

Label	Stats / Values	Freqs (% of Valid)	Valid
Pension distributive justice	1. Strongly disagree	296 (17.5%)	1694 (100.0%)
	2. Disagree	687 (40.6%)	
	3. Neither agree nor disagree	235 (13.9%)	
	4. Agree	419 (24.7%)	
	5. Strongly agree	57 (3.4%)	
Social class	1. Service class (I+II)	146 (8.6%)	1694 (100.0%)
	2. Intermediate class (III+I)	459 (27.1%)	
	3. Working class (V+VI+VII)	421 (24.9%)	
	4. Out of labor force	668 (39.4%)	
People are rewarded for their efforts	1. Strongly disagree	174 (10.3%)	1694 (100.0%)
	2. Disagree	776 (45.8%)	
	3. Neither agree nor disagree	379 (22.4%)	
	4. Agree	335 (19.8%)	
	5. Strongly agree	30 (1.8%)	
People are rewarded for their intelligence	1. Strongly disagree	142 (8.4%)	1694 (100.0%)
	2. Disagree	676 (39.9%)	
	3. Neither agree nor disagree	429 (25.3%)	
	4. Agree	418 (24.7%)	
	5. Strongly agree	29 (1.7%)	

3.2.4 Controls

Based on previous research ([Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2025](#); [Jaime-Castillo, 2013](#); [Lindh, 2015](#)), the statistical models include sociodemographic and attitudinal controls to account for potential compositional effects in the population. We adjust for sex (1 = male, 2 = female), age (in years), educational attainment (1 = less than university, 2 = university), and political identification (1 = left, 2 = centre, 3 = right, 4 = no identification). Following Langsæther et al. ([2022](#)), we do not control for income, as it can be conceived as a consequence of social class—that is, a post-treatment variable—and thus risks introducing collider bias into the estimates. Descriptive statistics for the control variables can be found in the Supplementary material.

3.3 Analytical Strategy

To examine longitudinal changes in pension inequality justification and its relationship with social class and meritocratic beliefs, we employ Cumulative Link Mixed Models (CLMM) for ordinal responses. This approach is particularly well-suited for our analytical goals for several reasons. First, it preserves the ordinal nature of our dependent variable without imposing assumptions about equal spacing between response categories. Second, it accounts for the hierarchical structure of our panel data, with repeated observations

(Level 1) nested within individuals (Level 2). Third, it enables the decomposition of variance into within-person (WE) and between-person (BE) components, allowing us to distinguish temporal changes within individuals from stable differences between individuals (Bell et al., 2019; Singer, 2003).

3.3.1 Within-Person and Between-Person Random Effects Models

Following the recommendations of Bell & Jones (2015), we decompose time-varying predictors into their within-person and between-person components using person-mean centering:

$$X_{WE_{it}} = X_{it} - \bar{X}_i$$

$$X_{BE_i} = \bar{X}_i$$

where X_{it} represents the observed value for individual i at time t , $\bar{X}_i$ is the person-specific mean across all observations, $X_{WE_{it}}$ captures within-person deviations from the individual mean (representing temporal fluctuations), and X_{BE_i} represents stable between-person differences (time-invariant characteristics).

This decomposition allows us to distinguish two theoretically distinct processes: (1) Within-person effects capture how changes in an individual's meritocratic beliefs over time relate to changes in their pension inequality justification, controlling for stable individual characteristics. (2) Between-person effects capture how individuals with different average levels of meritocratic beliefs differ in their pension inequality justification, net of temporal fluctuations.

3.3.2 Model Specification

The general form of our cumulative link mixed model is:

$$\eta_{it} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{time}_{it} + \beta_2 X_{WE_{it}} + \beta_3 X_{BE_i} + \beta_4 \text{Class}_i + \beta_5 (\text{Class}_i \times X_{WE_{it}}) + \beta_6 (\text{Class}_i \times X_{BE_i}) + u_{0i} + u_{1i} \text{time}_{it}$$

where η_{it} is the linear predictor for individual i at time t , linked to the cumulative probabilities through a logit link function; β_0 is the fixed intercept (threshold); β_1 captures the linear time trend; β_2 and β_3 represent within-person and between-person effects of meritocratic perceptions, respectively; β_4 captures social class between effects; β_5 and β_6 represent interactions between social class and within/between-person meritocratic perceptions; u_{0i} is the random intercept (capturing unobserved individual heterogeneity); and u_{1i} is a random slope for time (allowing individual-specific temporal trajectories).

The random effects are assumed to follow a bivariate normal distribution:

$$\begin{pmatrix} u_{0i} \\ u_{1i} \end{pmatrix} \sim N \left(\begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} \sigma_{u_0}^2 & \sigma_{u_{01}} \\ \sigma_{u_{01}} & \sigma_{u_1}^2 \end{pmatrix} \right)$$

3.3.3 Model Building Strategy

We estimate a series of nested models to test our hypotheses:

1. **Model 1 (Time Effects):** Baseline model examining temporal trends with linear and quadratic time terms
2. **Model 2 (Class Effects):** Adds social class as a predictor
3. **Model 3 (Within-Person Effects):** Includes within-person meritocratic beliefs
4. **Model 4 (Between-Person Effects):** Adds between-person meritocratic beliefs
5. **Model 5 (Full Model with Controls):** Incorporates sociodemographic controls (education, political identification, sex, age)
6. **Model 6 (Interactions):** Tests interactions between social class and meritocratic beliefs (both WE and BE)

All models are estimated using maximum likelihood with the Hessian matrix computed explicitly to obtain standard errors. Longitudinal survey weights are applied to account for the complex sampling design and panel attrition. Models are implemented using the `clmm()` function from the `ordinal` package in R (Christensen, 2019).

4 Results

4.1 Descriptive analysis

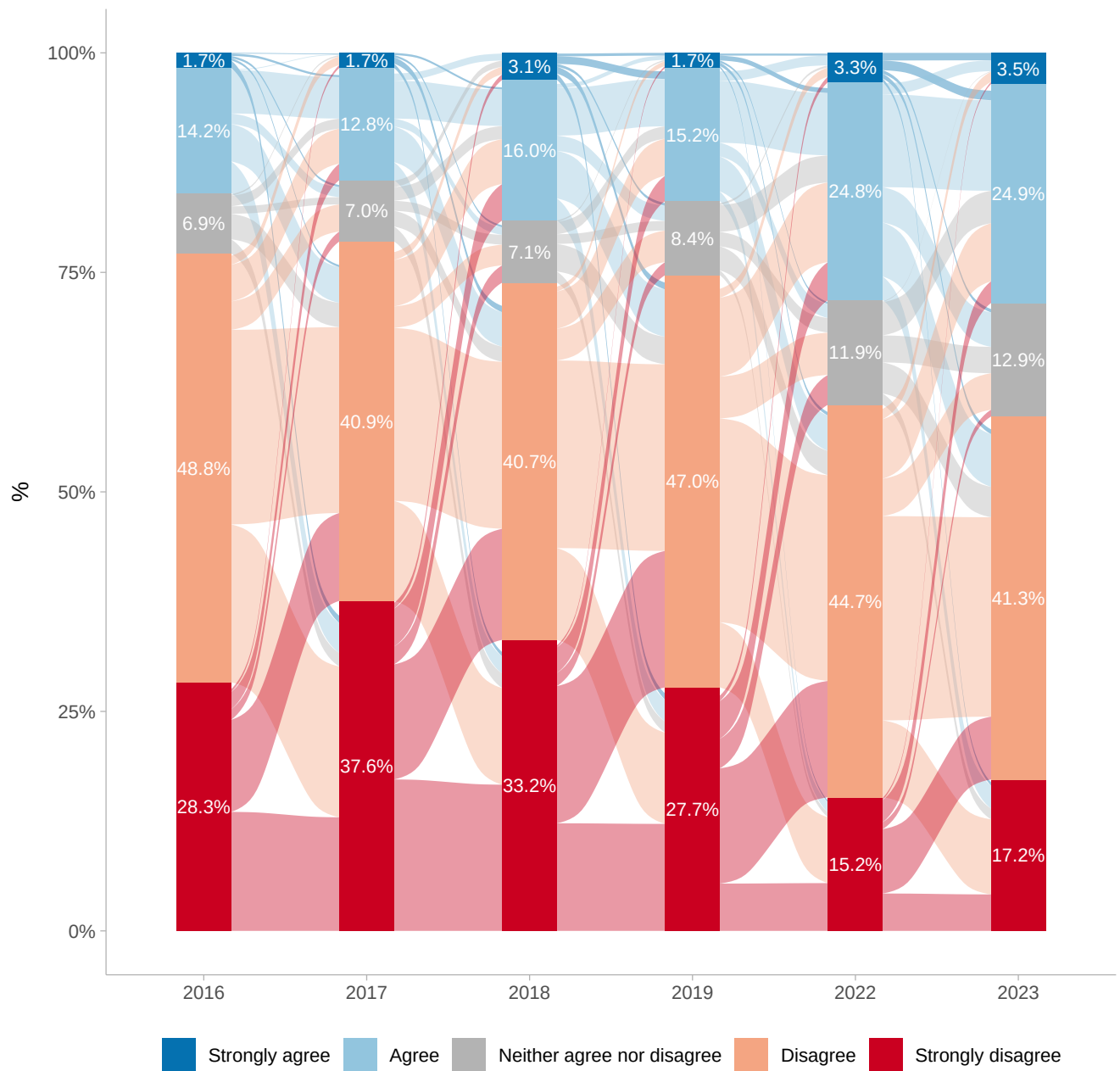


Figure 1: Changes in the justification of inequality in pensions over time (2016-2023)

Figure 1 shows the evolution over time of market justice preferences in pensions between 2016 and 2023. The results reveal a remarkable fluidity in attitudes: the extensive cross-flows between categories show that a considerable proportion of individuals change their position over time, rather than maintaining fixed opinions. Transitions occur predominantly between adjacent categories, suggesting gradual changes

rather than radical conversions, although some flows cross multiple categories.

The intermediate category (orange) emerges as the largest and functions as a ‘transit zone,’ receiving and losing people to both ends of the spectrum. The extremes—strong rejection (dark red) and strong agreement (dark blue)—maintain relative stability, representing hard cores of opinion that persist over time. Notably, the 2020-2021 period shows greater turbulence in transitions, coinciding with the Chilean social unrest and the pandemic, which would suggest that these attitudes are sensitive to socio-political and economic events in the national context. Overall, the data show that opinions on the fairness of pension inequalities are more malleable than expected, responding both to individual experiences (such as the cohort’s approach to retirement age) and to changes in the public debate on the Chilean pension system.

4.2 Bivariate relationships

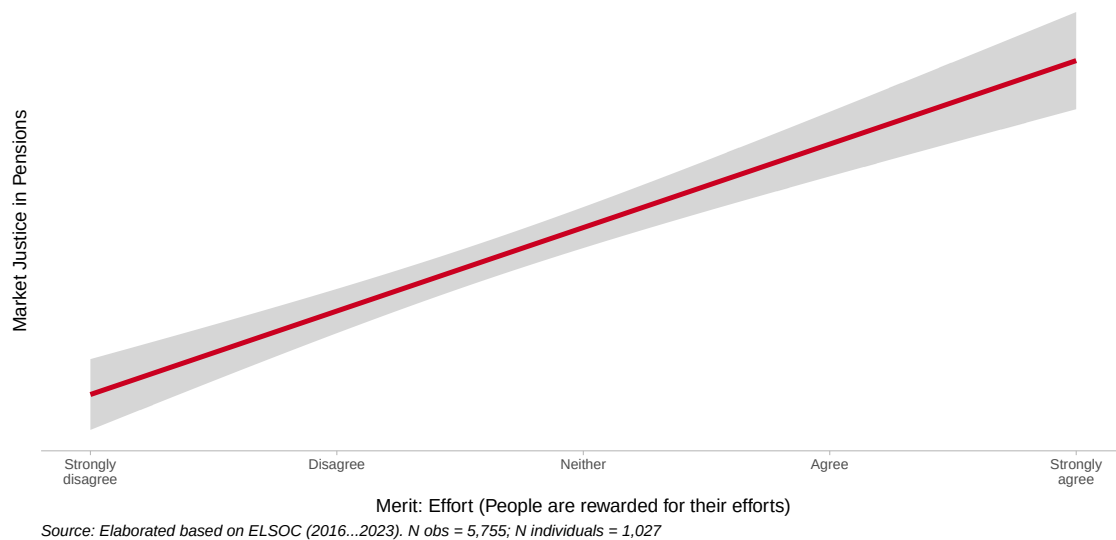


Figure 2: Bivariate relationship between meritocratic beliefs and market justice in pensions

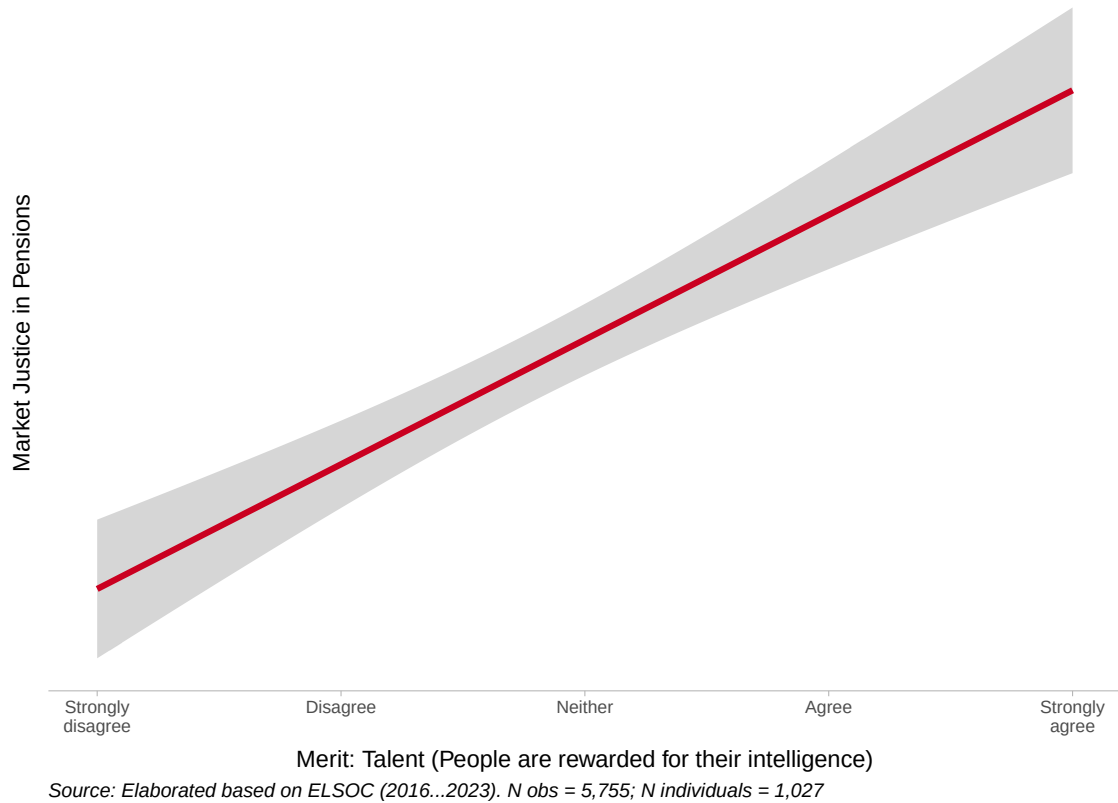


Figure 3: Bivariate relationship between merit (talent) and market justice in pensions

Figure 2 and Figure 3 present the bivariate relationships between meritocratic beliefs and market justice preferences in pensions. Both figures reveal a clear positive linear association: as individuals increasingly agree that society rewards effort (Figure 2) or talent (Figure 3), they are more likely to justify inequalities in the pension system. The regression lines, accompanied by their 95% confidence intervals (shaded areas), demonstrate statistically significant relationships across the full range of both independent variables, with the confidence bands remaining relatively narrow throughout, indicating robust and precise estimates.

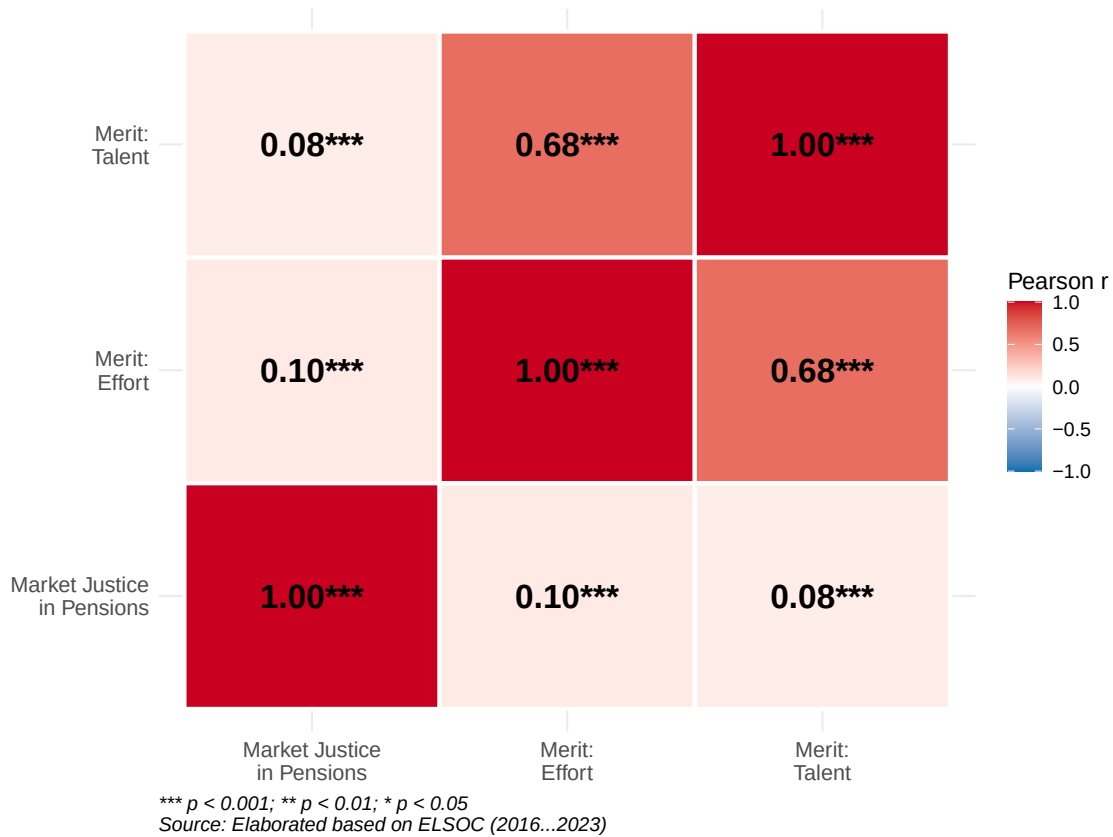


Figure 4: Correlation matrix between meritocratic beliefs and market justice

The strength of these bivariate associations is further quantified in Figure 4, which presents the correlation matrix between the three key variables. The correlation between Merit: Effort and Market Justice in Pensions is $r = 0.10$ ($p < 0.001$), while the correlation between Merit: Talent and Market Justice in Pensions is slightly weaker at $r = 0.08$ ($p < 0.001$). Although both correlations are modest in magnitude, they are highly statistically significant given the large sample size ($N_{\text{obs}} = 5,755$; $N_{\text{individuals}} = 1,027$). Notably, the two meritocratic belief dimensions—effort and talent—show a strong positive correlation with each other ($r = 0.68$, $p < 0.001$), suggesting they tap into a common underlying meritocratic worldview, while maintaining sufficient independence to be examined as distinct constructs.

These bivariate patterns provide initial empirical support for the theoretical expectation that meritocratic beliefs are associated with greater acceptance of market-based pension inequalities. However, the relatively modest effect sizes indicate that the relationship is not deterministic and that other factors—such as social class position, political ideology, and individual experiences with the pension system—likely play important moderating or confounding roles. The subsequent multivariate analyses will test whether these bivariate associations hold when controlling for relevant covariates and will explore potential interaction effects between meritocratic beliefs and social class, as hypothesized in our theoretical framework.

4.3 Multilevel models

Table 2 reports estimates from the cumulative multilevel models of support for pension market justice, distinguishing effects operating between individuals and within individuals over time. The intraclass correlation coefficient (?) from the null model (see Supplementary Material), which partitions the total variance in the outcome, is 0.24. This implies that about 24% of the variance lies between individuals, while the remaining 76% reflects within-person change across survey waves.

Model 1, which adds survey-wave indicators to capture temporal shifts in the outcome, shows a decline in 2017 ($\beta = -0.337, p < 0.001$) relative to 2016. By contrast, the 2022 and 2023 waves exhibit significant increases in market justice preferences for pension ($\beta = 0.879, p < 0.001$; $\beta = 0.854, p < 0.001$), indicating a nonlinear pattern over time. To account for this trajectory, Model 2 specifies time (survey wave) as a continuous predictor and includes a quadratic term to capture the curvature suggested by Model 1. The negative linear coefficient indicates an overall downward trend in market-based access to old-age pension benefits, whereas the positive quadratic term signals a subsequent upturn in the final measurement points.

Model 3 adds between-group effects (BE) for social class, capturing differences in average support for pension market justice across class locations. Overall, the estimates provide no evidence of systematic class differences in the support for market-based access to old-age pension benefits. Using the working class as the reference group, those in the intermediate class ($\beta = 0.10, p > 0.05$), the service class ($\beta = 0.17, p > 0.05$), retirees ($\beta = 0.10, p > 0.05$), and the unemployed ($\beta = 0.10, p > 0.05$) exhibit positive coefficients, but none reach conventional levels of statistical significance. Likewise, individuals performing unpaid work (e.g., domestic or care work) show a negative coefficient relative to the working class, which is not statistically significant ($\beta = -0.20, p > 0.05$). Taken together, these results suggest that neither class position nor being outside the labour force is clearly associated with differences in preferences for pension market justice at the between-individual level.

Models 4 and 5 extend the analysis by incorporating the within-person (WE) and between-person (BE) components of the meritocratic variables. Model 4 examines how changes in individuals' meritocratic perceptions over time relate to their views on pension market justice. The estimates show that the within-effect of perceiving that effort is rewarded is positive and highly significant ($p < 0.001$). Holding all other predictors constant, a one-point increase in effort-based meritocratic perceptions for the same respondent between waves is associated with a 0.11-point increase in the support for market-based access to old-age pension benefits. Model 5, which captures between-person differences, points in the same direction. On average, respondents who see their society as more effort-meritocratic display stronger market-oriented views on pensions, with a 0.39-point higher score on the outcome, a statistically significant association. By contrast, the corresponding indicators for the belief that intelligence and ability are rewarded show no statistically significant association with the support for market-based access to old-age pension benefits at either the within ($\beta = 0.07, p > 0.05$)- or between-person level ($\beta = 0.08, p > 0.05$).

Model 6 introduces the control variables. The within- and between-effects of the main predictors remain stable in both sign and significance, indicating that the associations are robust (see Supplementary Material for the effects of the control variables).

Table 2: Cumulative link longitudinal multilevel models for pension market justice preferences

Table 3

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5	Model 6
Wave (Ref.= 2016)						
Wave 2017	−0.337*** (0.079)					
Wave 2018	−0.013 (0.078)					
Wave 2019	0.086 (0.077)					
Wave 2022	0.879*** (0.078)					
Wave 2023	0.854*** (0.077)					
Wave		−0.182** (0.064)	−0.179** (0.064)	−0.187** (0.064)	−0.190** (0.064)	−0.192** (0.064)
Wave ²		0.059*** (0.009)	0.058*** (0.009)	0.060*** (0.009)	0.060*** (0.009)	0.060*** (0.009)
Social class (Ref.= Working class (V+VI+VII))						
Intermediate class (III+IV)			0.096 (0.120)	0.101 (0.121)	0.147 (0.118)	0.185 (0.117)
Service class (I+II)			0.169 (0.108)	0.169 (0.108)	0.158 (0.106)	0.017 (0.109)
Retired or pensioner			0.103 (0.117)	0.096 (0.117)	0.030 (0.115)	0.110 (0.127)
Unemployed			0.101 (0.158)	0.105 (0.158)	0.147 (0.155)	0.119 (0.152)
Performs unpaid tasks			−0.199 (0.110)	−0.198 (0.111)	−0.208 (0.109)	0.029 (0.113)
Merit: Effort (WE)				0.114** (0.035)	0.117*** (0.035)	0.115** (0.035)
Merit: Talent (WE)				0.066 (0.034)	0.066 (0.034)	0.067 (0.034)
Merit: Effort (BE)					0.391*** (0.097)	0.387*** (0.093)
Merit: Talent (BE)					0.079 (0.097)	0.028 (0.094)
Controls	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
BIC	19107.264	19166.031	19199.863	19182.632	19144.360	19097.183
Numb. obs.	7522	7522	7522	7522	7522	7522
Num. groups: individuals	1317	1317	1317	1317	1317	1317
Var: individuals (Intercept)	1.151	1.334	1.302	1.288	1.146	1.014
Var: individuals, wave		0.018	0.018	0.015	0.015	0.016

Note: Cells contain regression coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. *** $p < 0.001$; ** $p < 0.01$; * $p < 0.05$.

Table 4: Interactions for social class, meritocracy, and pension market justice preferences

Table 5

	Model 7	Model 8	Model 9	Model 10
Social class (Ref.= Working class (V+VI+VII) x Meritocracy (WE))				
Intermediate class (III+IV) x Merit: Effort (WE)	0.109 (0.100)			
Service class (I+II) x Merit: Effort (WE)	0.080 (0.089)			
Retired or pensioner x Merit: Effort (WE)	0.020 (0.091)			
Unemployed x Merit: Effort (WE)	0.087 (0.134)			
Performs unpaid tasks x Merit: Effort (WE)	0.033 (0.092)			
Intermediate class (III+IV) x Merit: Talent (WE)		0.171 (0.099)		
Service class (I+II) x Merit: Talent (WE)		0.091 (0.089)		
Retired or pensioner x Merit: Talent (WE)		0.050 (0.091)		
Unemployed x Merit: Talent (WE)		0.257* (0.131)		
Performs unpaid tasks x Merit: Talent (WE)		0.174 (0.092)		
Social class (Ref.= Working class (V+VI+VII) x Meritocracy (BE))				
Intermediate class (III+IV) x Merit: Effort (BE)			0.390 (0.201)	
Service class (I+II) x Merit: Effort (BE)			0.157 (0.172)	
Retired or pensioner x Merit: Effort (BE)			0.225 (0.182)	
Unemployed x Merit: Effort (BE)			0.153 (0.248)	
Performs unpaid tasks x Merit: Effort (BE)			-0.095 (0.167)	
Intermediate class (III+IV) x Merit: Talent (BE)				0.401* (0.191)
Service class (I+II) x Merit: Talent (BE)				0.222 (0.174)
Retired or pensioner x Merit: Talent (BE)				0.111 (0.182)
Unemployed x Merit: Talent (BE)				0.123 (0.257)
Performs unpaid tasks x Merit: Talent (BE)				-0.157 (0.174)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
BIC	19167.451	19152.429	19152.225	19150.549
Numb. obs.	7522	7522	7522	7522
Num. groups: individuals	1317	1317	1317	1317
Var: individuals (Intercept)	1.112	1.116	1.073	1.063
Var: individuals, wave	0.014	0.013	0.015	0.015
Var: individuals, merit effort cwc	0.112			
Var: individuals, merit talent cwc		0.142		

Note: Cells contain regression coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. *** $p < 0.001$; ** $p < 0.01$; * $p < 0.05$. CWC = centered within group.

To examine whether meritocratic perceptions condition class differences in market justice preferences in pensions, Table 4 reports four interaction models that combine between-person social class with the within- and between-person components of meritocratic perceptions. Model 7 includes interactions between class and within-person effort-based meritocracy; Model 8 does the same for within-person talent-based meritocracy; Model 9 interacts class with between-person effort-based meritocracy; and Model 10 with between-person talent-based meritocracy. Overall, the interaction terms are small and mostly non-significant, and model fit improves only marginally relative to the baseline specifications, suggesting that the link between meritocratic perceptions and market justice preferences in pensions is broadly similar across social classes.

Two interaction effects stand out as exceptions to this general pattern. In Model 8, the interaction between unemployment and within-person talent-based meritocracy is positive and statistically significant ($\beta = 0.26$, $p < 0.05$), indicating that, among unemployed respondents, increases over time in the perception that intelligence and ability are rewarded are more strongly associated with stronger support for market-based access to old-age pension benefits than among working-class respondents. In Model 10, the interaction between an intermediate-class position and between-person talent-based meritocracy is also positive and significant ($\beta = 0.40$, $p < 0.05$), implying that, within the intermediate class, individuals who more strongly believe that talent is rewarded display a steeper increase in market-oriented views on pensions than their working-class counterparts. Taken together, the evidence points to a largely homogeneous association between meritocracy and justice, with only limited moderation, concentrated in the talent dimension and in specific non-core classes.

5 Discussion

Survey evidence from 2016 to 2023 points to marked ambivalence among Chileans in their evaluation of market-based pension justice. In each wave, clear majorities reject the notion that it is fair for higher-income individuals to receive better pensions than lower-income individuals. At the same time, a small but expanding segment of respondents endorses this income-based principle, with the steepest growth occurring between 2018 and 2023. Market allocation of pension benefits thus remains a minority preference, yet one that has become more prevalent over time, in line with longitudinal evidence of rising support for income-based access to welfare services in Chile ([Juan Carlos Castillo et al., 2025](#)). These attitudes are formed within an institutional architecture of mandatory, privately managed, defined-contribution accounts that closely tie old-age income to labor earnings, contribution stability, and market performance ([Madero-Cabib et al., 2019](#); [Solimano, 2021](#)), and that symbolically recast pensions from solidarity-based social rights into individual financial assets. In this respect, Chile mirrors broader findings that income-based access to welfare is more strongly endorsed in liberal, marketised regimes ([Lindh, 2015](#)). Taken together, these patterns suggest that support for pension commodification, although contested and far from hegemonic, constitutes a salient orientation that raises the question of which social trajectories and belief structures sustain it.

6 Conclusion

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